



Leptis Magna

An ancient Phoenician port transformed into a major Roman city by the Emperor Septimius Severus

Situated on a natural harbor in present-day Al Khums at the mouth of the Wadi LebDAH on the coast of Libya, Leptis Magna was well placed to be a thriving Mediterranean port. It became a Roman colony in the 2nd century CE and underwent extensive expansion and regeneration during the reign of Septimius Severus (r.193–211 CE), a native of Leptis. As a result of his ambitious building program, Leptis became one of the most important—and most handsome—cities of Roman Africa. Among the improvements Severus initiated was the enlargement of the harbor and improvement of its piers and facilities, along with a substantial development of the infrastructure of the town, and its expansion to the south and west.

Past glories

Today, the ruins of Leptis are a testament to the vision Severus had for the town: the grid plan of streets, with a colonnaded thoroughfare linking the town center and the harbor; provision of public facilities—often using marble and granite—including the forum, bathhouses, and a theater; and grand monuments such as the basilica and the magnificent central archway.

Leptis fell to Arab invasion in the 7th century, and was abandoned soon after, but remained in a remarkable state of preservation as revealed by its excavation during the 20th century.

< FEARFUL DECORATION

Found in the Severan Forum, this carved ornament depicts the snake-haired Medusa, a fearsome gorgon reputed to have originated in Libya.



Severus built an **aqueduct** almost **13 miles (20 km)** long to supply the city with **water**



< GRAND BASILICA

The grandest of the many well-preserved structures at Leptis Magna is the basilica, a building for official, legal, and public functions, commissioned by Severus.

△ NEW CITY

The scale of Severus's development of Leptis Magna is evident in the theater and the Severan Forum above the old port.

CITY DESIGN

Under the reign of Septimius Severus, the old harbor town was substantially redeveloped, and a "New Town" was added above it to the southwest. This was designed on a typically Roman grid plan, with the main streets leading down to the old center and renovated harbor.



KEY

■ Arches
■ Baths

■ Churches and temples
■ Other buildings